

Speaker A: Have you had your lunch?

Speaker B: Yes sir, lunch was had by me.

The response of speaker B is grammatically correct, but it is not appropriate to the informal situation in which the conversation is taking place. However, our primary concern in this unit is with the notion of grammaticality. Here we have identified errors made by language users in terms of concord, verb forms, word order, uses of prepositions and conjunction among others.

13.3. ERRORS OF CONCORD

The term 'concord' in grammar refers to the syntactic agreement that takes place between the subject and the verb at the levels of number and person of the subject in a sentence. It implies that a singular subject takes a singular verb and a plural subject takes a plural verb as the following examples show.

- (a) I am reading a book
- (b) We are playing cricket.
- (c) You are not listening to me.
- (d) She is making tea.
- (e) They are not students.

In the above sentences we note that *I* agrees with *am*; *We/You/They* agree with *are* and *She* agrees with *is*. They look fairly straightforward and yet very often they tend to be problematic and be the cause of errors. Let us see how such errors in concord take place. The sentences beginning with asterisk (*) are considered wrong or unacceptable.

1. When two or more singular subjects are joined by *and* to refer to two separate person or things, a plural verb is used. But when they refer to the same person, a singular verb is used.
 - (a) *It has been reported that the Principal and Secretary were to sign the order.

It has been reported that the Principal and Secretary was to sign the order.

- (b) *It has been reported that the Principal and the Secretary was to sign the order.

It has been reported that the Principal and the Secretary were to sign the order.

- (c) *The inspecting officials were impressed that bread and butter were served to the refugees in the relief camp.

The inspecting officials were impressed that bread and butter was served to the refugees in the relief camp.

2. When two or more singular nouns are joined by *with*, *together with*, *as well as*, *either*, *neither*, a singular verb is used.

- (a) *The local MLA together with his wife are visiting the fair ground.
The local MLA together with his wife is visiting the fair ground.

- (b) *Each of these projects are funded by the World Bank.
Each of these projects is funded by the World Bank.

3. When the subject is a collective noun, a singular verb is used.

- (a) *The team comprising of IAS and IPS officers are to study various issues in the Indo-Bangla Border.

The team comprising of IAS and IPS officers is to study various issues in the Indo-Bangla border.

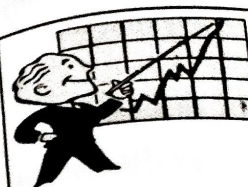
- (b) *The All Assam Students' Union, in a press statement, have appealed to the officers to strike down the names of foreigners without any fear.

The All Assam Students' Union, in a press statement, has appealed to the officers to strike down the names of foreigners without fear.

4. When the subject is a noun that follows.

- (a) *There are a huge number of people.
There is a huge number of people.

- (b) *There is five people.
There are five people.



Q. 1. Correct the errors.

- (a) Oil and water are mixed.
(b) The information is very useful.
(c) Bread and butter are served to the refugees.
(d) Both the boys are playing.
(e) There was a rally.
(f) All the members are present.
(g) The Brahmaputra is flowing.
(h) The officer is very kind.

13.4. ERRORS

The term 'collective noun' refers to a noun that refers to a group of people or things.

- (a) The committee are to meet tomorrow.
(b) The committee is to meet tomorrow.
(c) The committee has decided to meet tomorrow.
(d) The committee have decided to meet tomorrow.
(e) The committee are to meet tomorrow.
(f) The committee is to meet tomorrow.
(g) The committee has decided to meet tomorrow.
(h) The committee have decided to meet tomorrow.

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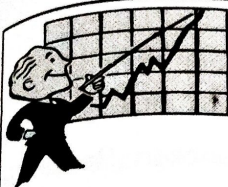
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A. When the subject is *There*, the verb agrees with the number of the noun that follows.

(a) *There are a huge rush for tickets for the IPL match.
There is a huge rush for tickets for the IPL match.

(b) *There is five lady teachers in the staff.
There are five lady teachers in the staff.



CHECK YOUR PROGRESS

Q. 1. Correct the following sentences:

- (a) Oil and water does not agree.
- (b) The informations are false.
- (c) Bread and butter are good breakfast.
- (d) Both the driver and the conductor was arrested.
- (e) There was a large number of party workers in the Minister's election rally.
- (f) All the major rivers of North India originates from the Himalayas.
- (g) The Brahmaputra as well as its tributaries flow through Tibet before flowing into India.
- (h) The officer have appointed a new typist.

13.4. ERRORS OF VERB FORMS

The term 'verb form' refers to the verb that carries the marker in terms of forms of grammatical categories such as tense, aspect, person etc and refers to an action or state. The forms of the verb include

- (a) The base form which implies that the verb does not have any prefix or suffix attached to it. It performs an imperative function (Come with me.); present tense function (You play very well.) and infinitive function (I like to play.).

- (b) The -s form which implies that the form consists of the base form and the -s suffix attached to it. It is used in third person singular number (He plays cricket.).
- (c) The past form which implies that an -ed suffix is attached to regular verbs (She played very well.) while irregular verbs form the past tense by a change of vowels (She wrote a letter) or undergoing no change as in a few cases (She put the book on the table). They express past tense.
- (d) The -ing form which implies that an -ing suffix is attached to the base form of the verb to perform a gerundial function (Reading is my hobby.) and active participle function (He is reading a book.).
- (e) The past participle form which is similar to the past form in regular and irregular verbs and generally ends with -en. (The book was given./ The thief was caught.)

Errors in the use of verb forms can be of various types some of which have been discussed below.

1. Certain verbs notably verbs of perception, feeling, states of mind, or relationships e.g. *see, hear, taste, feel, smell*, are not used in the present continuous tense. When one of these verbs is used to express an activity or a state that is still continuing, the simple present tense is used. This is a major area of errors of users of English in the use of verb forms.

(a) *I am not seeing anything outside.
I don't see anything outside.

(b) *Are you hearing that noise?
Do you hear that noise.

(c) *I am feeling a
I feel a sharp pain

(d) *She is loving
She loves s

(e) *I am recogniz
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(c) *I am feeling a sharp pain at this spot.
I feel a sharp pain at this spot.

(d) *She is loving swimming very much.
She loves swimming very much.

(e) *I am recognizing you now.
I recognize you now.

2. A lot of common errors occur with the wrong use of the verb e.g. mixing up verbs like *stay – live, say – tell, hear – listen, do – commit* etc. a few examples are given.

(a) *I spoke to him to go.
I told him to go./I asked him to go.

(b) *She says French fluently.
She speaks French fluently.

(c) *Hear the advice of your teacher.
Listen to the advice of your teacher.

(d) *The doctor saw the pulse of the patient.
The doctor felt the pulse of the patient.

(e) *He denied to follow me.
He refused to follow me.

(f) *Please see my certificates.
Please look at my certificates.

3. A lot of errors occur due to the wrong use of the tenses which include confusing present perfect with the past, past perfect with the past and

so on. A few examples are given.

(a) *We have met them a year ago.

We met them a year ago.

(b) *I had gone to Kolkata this vacation.

I went to Kolkata this vacation.

(c) *I have worked here since one year.

I have worked here for one year.

(d) *He will come when he will be ready.

He will come when he is ready.

(e) *It's time that you go home.

It's time that you went home.



CHECK YOUR PROGRESS

Q. 2. Rewrite the sentences correctly

(a) I am understanding what you say.

(b) Hear your teacher in the class attentively.

(c) He has left ten minutes ago.

(d) He tells me a fool.

(e) He has not eaten his dinner.

(f) We are living here since 2000.

(g) He informed the matter to the police.

(h) She could not help to go there.

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13.5. ERRORS OF ORDER

Order refers to the arrangement of words in a sentence, generally called word order. There is a definite word order for the assertive sentence. But when you look at the word order of a wh-question, you find a subject-verb inversion taking place. That is the order of an interrogative sentence. Similarly indirect questions and embedded questions have a definite word order. Here we shall look at some of the errors that users of English make at the level of word order.

1. Adjective phrases that are in an attributive position (i.e. before a noun in a noun phrase) may contain more than one adjective. When more than one adjective is placed before a noun in a noun phrase, the adjectives follow a definite word-order e.g. quality + length + colour + nationality.
 - (a) * She is an old dignified lady.
= She is a dignified old lady.
 - (b) * Her face lit up with a cheerful bright smile.
= Her face lit up with a bright cheerful smile.
2. When there are two or more adverbs after a verb (and its object), the normal order is adverb of manner + adv of place + adverb of time.
 - (a) * She sang last night at the concert beautifully.
= She sang beautifully at the concert last night.
 - (b) * He spoke in the meeting well.
= He spoke well in the meeting.
3. Subject – verb inversion takes place both in indirect and direct questions.
 - (a) * Tell me what is her name.
= Tell me what her name is.

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13.6 ERRORS OF PREPOSITIONS

Prepositions are words used with nouns or noun equivalents to show the relation in which these nouns stand to some other word in a sentence thus in the sentence "The book is on the table", the preposition *on* expresses the relation between *the book* and *the table*.

The preposition and the noun together make a prepositional phrase in a sentence as in "He is in the room" where in the room is a prepositional phrase.

Prepositions may be single words eg *on, at, in, by, after, before*, etc. or they may be more than one word as in *instead of, in front of, for the sake of, at the back of*, etc.

1. A major cause of errors in the use of prepositions is the wrong omission of these words in a sentence.

(a) * Open page 75.

Open at page 75.

(b) *He has not replied your letter.

He has not replied to your letter.

(c) *Beware car thieves.

Beware of car thieves.

2. While in the above examples, the prepositions are wrongly omitted, in the following examples, the prepositions are wrongly used.

(a) *You should repent for your misdeeds.

You should repent your misdeeds.

(b) *It has been raining from morning.

It has been raining since morning.

(c) * He was forced to resign from his post.

He was forced to resign his post.



13.7. ERRORS OF CONJUNCTIONS

We use words and phrases to join or to connect elements in a sentence or a paragraph. These connecting devices are conjunctions. e.g.

- (a) India and China are neighbouring countries.
- (b) You may give me either a cup of tea or a glass of water.
- (c) She tried hard but was unsuccessful.

The following are examples of conjunctions.

- 1. and, as well as, also, to,
- 2. but, yet, still, however, while,

3. or, else, otherwise
4. so, therefore, for, hence
5. either...or, neither...nor,
both....and, though...yet,
whether...or, not only...but also,
hardly...when, no sooner...than,
such...as, scarcely...when etc.

Here we shall look at a few types of errors in the use of conjunctions.

- (a) * When it stopped raining, then I went out for a walk.
When it stopped raining, I went out for a walk.
- (b) * Though he was tired, but he continued to work.
Though he was tired, he continued to work.
- (c) * As the weather was fine, so the children had great fun.
As the weather was fine, the children had great fun.
- (d) * If you work hard, then you will surely do well in the exams.
If you work hard, you will surely do well in the exams.
- (e) * Not only he is wise, but strong also.
He is not only wise, but also strong.
- (f) * Hardly had I reached home, than it began to rain.
Hardly had I reached home when it began to rain.
- (g) * Either you are mad or pretend to be so.
You are either mad or pretend to be so.
- (h) * He looks as if he was tired.
He looks as if he were tired.

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